

2000 - 62

CFO-ORC FIL

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

7-0 (A)

Rec'd 12/4/00 wpl

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD _____

Species: Great Black-backed Gull (*Larus marinus*)**Date:** 4 January 1998**Number seen:** one**Sex:** ?**Plumage:** Basic I**Locality:** Arvada Res.**Elevation:** about 5850'**Nearest town:** Arvada**County:** Jefferson**Time observed:** early afternoon**Duration of observation:** about 15 minutes

Description: While scoping Arvada Res. from SR 93 on the trial run of the Westminster-Golden CBC (not rerun as of this writing), Nick Komar and I found a large immature gull that appeared to be a Great Black-backed. We spent some looking at it from the highway and then decided that we really needed to get better views. We finally found a way to get closer (through Arvada Park at SR 93 and 172 Rd.; DeLorme pg. 40, B1; southwest of Tucker Lake - the reservoir is not depicted on the map) and refound the bird and studied it for a bit more. Though it was still a fair distance away, we were able to confirm it as a Great Black-backed in Basic I.

The gull was in with about 100 other gulls, mostly Ring-bills (RBGU), but with two Californias (CAGU). It was substantially larger than all of the other gulls present, even the CAGUs. Its head was very pale, almost whitish, and it had a large, black bill. The eye was seemingly very small relative to the head size. The mantle was grayish-brown and contrasted with the blackish outer primaries, the pale, translucent inner primaries, and the blackish secondaries. The inner primary window was fairly obvious, but not as obvious as would be typical for a first-year Herring Gull. The rump appeared all white, though the distance could have precluded us from detecting any dark spotting. The tail was mostly white with a strong, black terminal/subterminal band and with some other black markings more toward the base, but in precisely what pattern we were unable to determine. The rump and tail pattern were very reminiscent of that of a RBGU. The underparts were very pale brown and white - mostly pale brown on the chest and sides and white on the belly. We did not note the leg color.

Similar species eliminated: Lesser Black-backed is eliminated by the mantle pattern and coloration (LBBG doesn't show an inner-primary window in Basic I and is much darker-mantled in that plumage), size (LBBG would be more similar to the size of the CAGUs present), and bill size. Old World races of Herring Gull are eliminated by size, eye size, and bill size. Slaty-backed Gull is ruled out by rump and tail pattern.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): No vocalizations heard.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I had seen >60 *graellsii* LBBGs on the Great Lakes and the East Coast, bazillions of *smithsonianus* HERGs, 10s of 1000s of GBBGs, and no similar ages of Slaty-backed.

Light conditions: behind me and to my right

Optical equipment used: Kowa 30x

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest approach at about 700 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Nick Komar, Jim Bradley, Sherrie York

Other observers who saw the bird independently: some, but I know not who (on 5 January 1998)

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph the bird.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none **b) after observation:** none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Tony Leukering", with a stylized flourish at the end.

Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: After looking at the reservoir again on 25 November 2000, I happened to recall that I hadn't, as yet, submitted this sighting. Therefore, when I got home, I tore my apartment apart looking for my notebook from that era and finally found it. I wrote this report immediately from notes that I wrote the evening of the sighting. Unfortunately, I had neglected to write the time of the sighting in my notebook, so my entry here is my remembrance of that - I wouldn't swear to the time being accurate.